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Jeannie and Jimmy Cheatham

Jeannie and Jimmy Cheatham have been creating swinging blues together since the late 50s, when they met in Buffalo, New York. Jimmy has played trombone with Duke Ellington, Lionel Hampton and Ornette Coleman, and taught jazz at Bennington College, the University of Wisconsin, and at the University of California at San Diego. His arrangements for the Sweet Baby Blues Band capture the Kansas City jump blues style and make the seven-piece band swing like Jay McShann and Count Basie.

Jeannie started as a classical piano student, but found a new sound to pursue after hearing Charlie Parker and Lester Young. She has accompanied Joe Williams, Big Mama Thornton and T-Bone Walker, and she was featured in the film "Three Generations of Blues" with Sippie Wallace and Ms. Thornton. This production was inducted into the Library of Congress' 1997 Jazz Film Series along with the film, "Jeannie & Jimmy Cheatham and the Sweet Baby Blues Band." They continue to add to their list of accomplishments from their home base in San Diego.

Jeannie and Jimmy were interviewed in San Diego, California on February 12, 1998, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: We are filming today in San Diego for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive. And I'm really thrilled to have today as our guests, Jeannie and Jimmy Cheatham, masters of the blues, and educators. And I wanted to tell you something that happened to me on the way out here. Before I got on the plane in Syracuse I was listening to some of your records. So all the way on the plane, all seven hours, I had this, "Baby, meet me with your black drawers on." That was in my head, all the way out here.

Jim: Imagine us doing that to ya.

MR: And you know that's the mark of a great tune.

Jean: It is.

MR: If it sticks with you like that.

Jim: That's it, man.

MR: How did you guys come up with that?

Jim: It's whistleable.

Jean: It just sort of came out. You know we were working on that first album, and we were just fooling around, and when we went in the studio, it was after the session was over, then we just went into — there was no arrangement or anything. And so we never dreamed they would ever put it on the record.

Jim: Strictly head.

Jean: We did it for fun. And so we thought it would be against the law or something. But they put it on the record.

Jim: Yeah, we thought they'd ban it. We were so surprised.

Jean: We were really shocked that it came out you know.

MR: I really like the end too, you said — remember what you said at the end?

Jim: That's Snooky.

MR: That's Snooky.

Jean: Snooky blamed Jimmy for a long time.

Jim: He blamed me, see, all the time.

Jean: He didn't want his wife to know that he was there.

Jim: He didn't want his wife to know that he said that, see? You know, so we had to cool it for a while, then all of a sudden, he got to liking it you know. So the next session, he became the director again —

Jean: Of the Glee Club.

Jim: Of the Glee Club, see?

Jean: Yeah, he's the official director.

Jim: Yeah, official director.

MR: Well for some of our maybe — students that will watch this later on, you said you know, that was a head arrangement.

Jim: Yeah, totally.

MR: Could you just, in your own words, explain about the head arrangement? Because that's a bit of a lost art these days.

Jim: Oh, yeah. Well one of the main reasons is due to the times, you know, because coming up in our era, and all the perennial giants who set the pace for everything you know, they did a lot of head playing, and specifically noted for that was the Kansas City style see? That's why we refer to the Kansas City style. In other words, riffs, tunes, and you make up a tune and you take it until you decide to—

Jean: To stop.

Jim: To stop. It could be all night. Really. Depends on the groove you know and everything. And so in other words, it just comes immediately, it's an improvisation right from — a spontaneous phrase right from the get-go, you know, from the head. And everybody's just tuning in to each other you know. While one is playing the lead, another will set up a tune, and they listen to it and make a little background to it or something like that. Or they'll pick up the tune as a total unison thing, and make it a big mass unison, and then go into solos and then riffs and things like that.

MR: And then it might get written down later.

Jim: Oh, yeah, later.

Jean: Yeah, especially if they like it. I think also that it's best to be taken from like Gospel or spiritual music you know? Because you always have a lead singer, or the preacher, he's doing his thing and everybody's saying "Amen." And then the preacher goes from the one to the third to the fifth to the seventh. And when he hits the seventh he's ready to take everybody out.

Jim: Yeah. That's how you get this going.

Jean: Yeah, I noted that even when I was little. And so whoever is playing the solo is the preacher for the moment. And everybody else is doing "Amen." And then the next soloist takes over, and he's the preacher for the moment, and everybody else says the "Amen." So it's really that simple.

Jim: Really.

Jean: But you've got to live it.

Jim: He'd follow — and soloists would follow that, would actually follow that format, in terms like she was saying, tonic, third, fifth, seventh. That's why each chorus —

Jean: Sort of grows.

Jim: Grows.

Jean: And it changes.

Jim: In other words you become aware of building. Like creativity. Like the law of creativity dictates that. In terms of the energy. Energizing.

MR: And when you got up to that seventh, that just kind of had to resolve eventually?

Jean: Eventually.

Jim: Eventually. Sometimes you'd just leave it hanging you see? So that's why you start having dominant chord endings, see?

MR: Oh. Come back next week and we'll find it.

Jim: We'll find it.

MR: Well you guys met on stage in the 50s? Now I read this and I want to know if it's true.

Jean: It's pretty much true.

Jim: Yeah, very much so, yeah. It was like a quick — she got a quick call I found out later, I had no idea she would be there and vice versa.

Jean: From the president of the union.

Jim: In Buffalo.

Jean: In Buffalo. Because we had come in from Toronto with our group to do the jam session, that went on all night long, one Sunday, at the musician's club.

Jim: At the musician's club, upstairs see?

Jean: And so the president said, "Jeannie, they need a piano player in there" what was that, the Elks or somewhere.

Jim: That was at — yeah.

Jean: I think it was the Elks Club.

Jim: Yeah, it was the Elks up on the—

MR: An Elks Club?

Jean: He said, "Would you go and play over there?" And I said, "This is my day off, I don't want to play the Elks." And he said, "Please," he said, "just do me a favor." And so when I came in there there was all these guys and then, really older guys, and so I knew they were going to play "Honeysuckle Rose"—

Jim: Yeah, you know, the standards.

MR: Right.

Jean: "Take the A Train," and whatever, so I said that would be an easy gig. And then Jimmy came in. And he was a younger guy.

Jim: I was the second youngest next to her.

Jean: Next to me, right. And so I said oh, wait a minute. So you know, all the musicians like put a dollar in a pile and we'd always get a bottle so we didn't have to buy it.

Jim: Yeah.

Jean: So that way, after the gig we used to sit around and tell tales you know. So I put my dollar in. And after the gig I looked around and I was going to talk to this guy — he had gone. He cut out. I didn't see him for three more years.

Jim: That's right.

MR: Really? That was almost the end right there.

Jean: Well almost.

Jim: And I had just come back from California, not too long beforehand. And so that was kind of a habitual thing. After the gig was over and the pack up, and as Papa Jo Jones would say, "With our mutual armies we'll move out smiling."

Jean: But I was always hanging around because I liked the stories. See because he had more of an advantage in that he had a chance to grow up listening to people and talking to people like Jo Jones and Ben Webster—

Jim: And Lester Young.

Jean: And Lester Young and all these people, because they were in the service with him.

Jim: Yeah. Chico Hamilton and — I slept in the top bunk and Chico slept on the bottom you see?

Jean: And I hadn't had that experience at all, because I stayed mostly up in Canada and in the middle part of the country where we played mostly. So I hadn't had a chance to meet any of the big guys like that.

Jim: She played a lot for those big singers — all the top singers.

Jean: I know, but that was later.

MR: Let me ask you about that in a moment. I wanted to ask you, at that time when you had first met, was there still a black musician's and a white musician's union?

Jim: Yeah.

Jean: Yeah.

Jim: Yeah. You see but I was part of the integration in Hollywood, see? Because I had finished school at the Westlake College of Music in Hollywood for film scoring and radio and T.V. and all of that, after I had finished the New York Conservatory of Modern Music in Brooklyn you see. And it was in that particular sojourn, and going to Hollywood for that, it's where I also challenged the Local 47, the white local, why they refused my card. I said well why can't I, as a transfer person, transfer it, and also become a member in due time, according to the rules and regulations? And they said well no, we can't accept you you know. So anyway, long story short, I had the Dr. Lernard, who was the director of the school, I went back and told him, because the school was right there on Vine and Yukon, in Hollywood, see. And so my whole reason was look, I'm here, in Hollywood, every day. And so Local 767, which is the black local, was way over on the east side you see, on Central Avenue. And so anyway, Dr. Lernard set up an appointment and we discussed it and everything. So we went through a whole lot of politics and everything. So anyway, the only satisfaction was that I brought them to admit, that the only reason why they wouldn't accept me was due to a gentleman's agreement. I knew they understood that, because I got that from high school. So I knew how to relate to them when it came to that. So I said well okay, I'll be back. And before I left, sure enough they had a caucus and got together and the unions merged, and the same people were in office, because they stay in office a pretty long time, 'til they die you know. And so when they came over to the 767 to make the graces and everything about the unions coming together, and be an amalgamated, see that was the word that was used, amalgamation — not integration or anything like that — amalgamation.

Jean: Mmm. There's a thought.

Jim: That was the word. And well that was due to the ACLU.

MR: I see.

Jim: It was a powerful move, believe me.

MR: And that year was—

Jim: This was like 195—— late 50s — like middle '53. Actually it was going on say from '52, '52 and then '53 when that finally happened — when it finally happened like in '53, late '53 or early '54.

MR: Did you both know you were going to be musicians at a young age?

Jean: Yes. I did.

MR: Let me ask you first.

Jean: I did. I knew that. I wanted to be an artist, but I started taking lessons very early, five, six years old, from a very good teacher from England, his name was Arthur Reginald Riley. And he was a very good teacher. I learned to play classical music and read everything and plus I played in church you see. So it was a very — it didn't seem unnatural for me. I knew that that was my life's work at a very early age. It was either that or be a school teacher and I knew I didn't want to be a school teacher.

MR: I think we're glad that you went the music route.

Jim: I am. Definitely.

Jean: There's nothing wrong with being a school teacher.

MR: Oh, it's an honorable profession.

Jim: It better be honorable because it don't pay. So you might as well be a — what you love doing — be a jazz musician and starve to death too.

MR: That's right, there's some similarities there.

Jean: Take a vow of poverty.

Jim: That's it.

MR: How about yourself? Was trombone your first instrument?

Jim: Actually baritone horn was my first instrument, in terms of performing on it, because my arm wasn't long enough to reach all the way out to the seventh position on the trombone, slide trombone you know. So the music instructor kind of smiled and says, "Look, see, you know you've got to grow a little more, to really deal with the horn." He says, "So if you don't mind me making a suggestion, how about playing a baritone horn?" I said, you know, okay. I wanted to get started you see. And so I stayed with the baritone horn for like the first year. And this was in grade school. And the following year, which was like seventh grade — I started in sixth grade — then I stayed with the baritone in seventh and then in eighth grade I went to the trombone you see. And made the orchestra and all that. But my first involvment in music performance was voice. I sang — I was also appointed as one of the members of the Hundred Voice Choir, a city boy choir in the city, all-city. And so I sang in the choir and also a solo. So that got me performing personally.

MR: And you learned to read music at that age, and the whole thing.

Jim: Oh yeah, yeah.

Jean: That shows you the difference in the school system, and also the city system. Because we had the same thing, everybody took music. It was a requirement. And they used to have like spring festivals and things, where your group from this school would go against this one, and you'd find the all-Ohio singers and they'd come and take the best out of everyone.

Jim: That's how it happened, yeah.

Jean: Just like sports. And the May festivals. And gee I played vocal choir, orchestra, they were doing musicals, and so we had to play for those people and they would put on a show every year. And this all in grade school mind you. And we still were taking math and everything else that we had to take.

Jim: But it was equally required.

Jean: It was just required, just like sports.

Jim: And right into high school. Because I played in the jazz band in high school, the orchestra, and also the marching band, and the marching band was the same as the pep band. Today they have the pep band and marching band, but at that time the marching band did both jobs. Because after the first year, in terms of my sophomore year, I actually went into playing football you see. But I was still playing in the orchestra, but I couldn't play in the marching band because like trying to be in two places at one time.

Jean: Well that would have been a good one, because you'd be flying over the stadium.

Jim: And you know it was so beautiful, the instructors were fantastic. I mean they had depth, breath and height, and I know you know what I'm talking about, as a human being, trained to transmit knowledge.

MR: So much more than just the music, right?

Jean: Oh, yeah. It was like a life thing.

Jim: And that's where I became — it struck a chord here. And that's it, I said I knew what I wanted to do. Which actually it was an affirmation really, and a confirmation. Because at home, before even getting into school, when I was like four and five years old — two and say three, after — I was born in Birmingham, Alabama but I came there when I was about three years old, two and a half to three years. But anyway, my uncle, in Buffalo, New York, had all the records. And the word — I didn't know it then, but — he was looking back, he was a very eclectic — he had a very eclectic ear. He had from country, spirituals, to opera, Lawrence Tibbett and I always recall her name, but Lily Pons. You know that's going back you know.

Jean: You never thought you'd say that, did you?

Jim: No, no. Because I'm watching his eyes. And naturally Caruso you see. And just name it, I heard all these, all this. And then we had the piano at the house—

Jean: Everybody had a piano at that time. Everybody had a piano.

Jim: Yeah, at that time. It's like everybody in the south had an organ way back earlier, you know what I mean? Had a little pump organ.

Jean: And now they've just begun to gather data about what that does to a child's spatial knowledge by — it has to do with music.

Jim: That's right.

Jean: And I'm not going out of here without them knowing that. Because we've said it for years, and so we've lived it.

Jim: And our structures, that's why you heard me say that — I didn't know you hadn't heard that, three dimensions, depth, breadth and height. Because you're dealing with a pyramid there.

MR: I'm going to pause for one second—This curtain was too close and it's rubbing the back of your head. You okay? So we'll just pick up, we'll edit that out.

That's so true with the education and sometimes I see kids who have a really hard time even clapping or moving to a beat. And I'm going, why is that? I want to know why that is. And I suspect it's because they don't have music in the house.

Jim: Oh, yeah.

Jean: Exactly.

MR: It doesn't sink in.

Jim: Because it's like we're more mass conscious I would say as of now, we're becoming much more aware of being aware of the power of music. Because what it can do subliminally, without any overt influences, is amazing. We haven't gotten to that yet.

MR: Well then do you feel that the negative influence is also possible? I mean there's a kind of controversy about a lot of the music that's out today, whether it be rap or heavy metal — some of the things that they're saying — if music can be a positive influence, can it also go the other way?

Jean: I don't really know. All I know is that some of the studies that I've been following find that the more simple, the simpler the music is, the more the child learns, even in utero. Like just a plain little chord — a 1-3-5 chord and maybe a 7th you know, later. And the simpler the music is, it seems to widen their spatial sense. And then they also find that vocal music also. But it has to be a certain type, simple again you see. So I have a feeling that they're going to find that each one of the chords have a power and really correspond to a part of the person's brain and body. So I'm thinking that pretty soon — they can measure this stuff now, I know they can.

Jim: In terms of brain waves.

Jean: See I know they can. And I'm quite sure that the powers that be, that keep saying that we don't need music in the schools —

Jim: That's the negative part.

Jean: That's more negative than rap, and I like rap on certain things, because they have a lot of people that teach very interesting things through rap. And the rhythm of the words is a power in itself. It's almost like haiku poetry if you want to talk about. Because that's in a sense, an art form in itself. One day we're going to probably peel away a couple of verses and things and say, oh this is really poetry, it's wonderful poetry.

Jim: Another interesting thing, not to oversimplify, but to me it's like getting right into the source, like looking into the sun but not too long because you can become blind as a bat. But the thing is is that we look at sound. Sound does not happen unless it has a vibrating body in some way, shape, form or fashion. But sound itself, the nature of sound, is emanated from a vibration. There is nothing that exists on this planet earth or in its environment or the universe that doesn't have, is not affected by vibration. The sun rays. How many miles — they say how many million miles, 83 million or something like that? But nobody's got that close to find out about it. But the point is, by even projecting that, you know that you feel the vibration of that heat. You follow me? And so that has to have, without a doubt, whatever, knowingly or unknowingly, some aspect of effect from a scientific point of view, on every living thing on this planet. Man.

MR: We'll have to sit and analyze that.

Jean: Well sure. But you know, Count Basie's music, and for some reason a lot of the people that call them connoisseurs or want to write all about music, for some reason they sort of leave him over here. And they're always talking about somebody else over here. But he knew exactly how to maintain order. He played his music and it corresponded to the heart beat. And he knew that. He was born to do that. He was one of the best at that, if you want to speak of something that he contributed. He really knew how to move and make a crowd feel wonderful because he never, he put that music right there, where it belonged, in the heartbeat.

Jim: And the most beautiful thing, hearing a thirteen, fourteen, fifteen, now seventeen piece band — or five, etcetera — at the time it was smaller. When he'd say "bing" — look out. And the band would say — oh.

MR: What power that was.

Jean: It's amazing. Now that's understood.

Jim: That's what I relate to my students. Just last night I had my rehearsal, on Tuesday and Wednesday nights, and every time we go through things, at the end of the chart, and I made them aware that if I say it over and over, in many different ways, about, I say believe me, music is powerful. I don't say jazz is powerful. I say music is powerful. Whatever its form or style is, and wherever it's coming from on this planet or anywhere else, in terms of the way to deal with the music of the spirits and try that. But the thing is, we haven't begun to even — we're just scratching the surface.

Jean: When they say harmony, you know we used to go to like an arranger's band in Buffalo, New York, where people could bring in different arrangements and we'd rehearse. And then we'd put on a big show.

Jim: We'd put on a showcase.

Jean: A showcase once a month. And we had this one guy, he would come in with these arrangements, and he would pass out the music, and everybody's feeling great. And he'd bring his hand down, and the band would fight — start this big fight. Believe me.

Jim: That first chord.

Jean: The first chord.

Jim: And all of a sudden everybody's like [growls].

Jean: Everybody yells, and punches, and they'd head for the bar and double Gugenheimer — you remember that?

Jim: Yeah, the Gugenheimer whiskey, that was a special at the club.

Jean: And Jimmy and I would watch this thing. I said, it was consistent. I said I don't care what he writes, every time he writes something, everybody starts fighting. See it's so much cacophony and so many notes.

Jim: And see that gnarling vibration see, all it matters is that it makes your nerve system catch a good hold of that, and he'd be sitting back like this.

Jean: Watching the set.

MR: Oh, he liked it.

Jim: He was aware of what he was doing. So when you spoke earlier, we could go around the track about the negative aspect you see.

MR: There you go.

Jim: Oh yes, yes. And you know just like in anything else. Just like the church. You've got the minister and it could be positive or he could be very negative at times, in the sense of power and controlling, from that point of view and that type of stuff. So it's always AC/DC, just like in terms of electricity. You've got to have a little negative and a little positive power in order to have a good pole of electricity.

MR: Well that's what — among the things I love about the blues is that you can play the quote wrong notes, the blue notes, that clash theoretically, but that they still sound so good.

Jean: Because they're bent.

MR: Because they're bent.

Jean: Yeah. They never go straight on.

Jim: And the other reason is because of dealing with the system in terms of the western world, we scientifically divided everything up. There's nothing wrong with that. But to make that the total aspect of what music is about, is where the negative aspect of conveying that message you see. When it came to opera, I mean [inaudible] — they didn't know anything about China. And anything that sounded strange, they would say it's Chinese music. But they're in deep trouble now you see. Globally, they're in deep trouble. All of a sudden they find out there's other people living elsewhere. And they have their respective cultures according to the creative process that we live in.

Jean: Pentatonic scales.

MR: And how does that fit in? How are we going to resolve that with our own eight note scale?

Jim: Well the whole thing is we're coming, see we come to grips with that because, again, when we speak in terms of poverty, at least from my point of view I like to look at the aspect of creation. You're dealing with such a fine sense, I say we are vibration — balance. And so we can go to China and say, or Japan and say yin yang, or wherever it is, they've got a word for balance you see. And music speaks strongly to the nature of what we all are about in terms of the creative process. And we have a choice how we wish to use it in terms of our given talents.

MR: Well said. Wow. Let me ask you about some things from years past. You had some big band experience along the way, with some of our more notable big band leaders.

Jim: Very fortunate, yeah.

MR: If you had to pick a time that was one of your favorites in one of those bands, what might it be?

Jim: Well I can't say favorites. Each one, in terms of the experience, what it offered me, was that same, like I say aspect of being uplifted.

Jean: There's nothing like a big band.

Jim: And maintaining an open mind you see. Now sure I could talk about being on the road, and the negative hassles, and etcetera. But the amazing thing about it all, because you're still sleeping and whatnot you know, and eating with the individuals, was on that bandstand.

Jean: Nothing like it. It's worth everything.

Jim: Everything became one. And there's all this diverse expression coming out of these horns. And from one section to the next, speaking to each other. Then in terms of mass unisons and you know, whatever, and solos, personal expression. And that whole band, just like when you hear Basie, it speaks.

Jean: And it was different when he was with Duke.

Jim: Duke Ellington.

Jean: And Maynard Ferguson. I really liked hanging around with that group. They were really hip.

MR: Was that the small big band with Maynard, or was it a whole—

Jim: No actually it was a big band. It was a time that he and what's his name, that was traveling with him then that was on the road together. He and Maynard would take this chemical or whatever it was. And they would stay out of their minds you know. But the thing is — I can't think of his name right now.

Jean: Yeah, well you probably better not.

Jim: But all I'm saying, the important thing is that, I mean this was a highly intellectual man. This was no, you know, peddler or anything like that. I mean he was highly respected as a human being. But that was the only time they were traveling on the road together. Willie Maiden was the straw boss. That's how I got in the band, because Willie Maiden and I finished Westlake College of Music together in Hollywood you see. And he called me up, they were on their way — in fact they were coming to Buffalo to play a gig, and he had found out that I was in Buffalo. And the trombone player had to go home to bury his dad in Texas. So he called me up and said, "Hey man, I'd like for you to come on over to this club we're playing and make this gig with us, because we don't want to show up short a man, because our contract could be voided."

Jean: Yeah. Then they don't want to pay you.

Jim: So at that time we had our jazz showcase going on and I was doing a lot of writing and stuff like that. I said, "Well I haven't been playing too much, really." We'd been doing a lot of writing and stuff, and he says, "Look Jim" he says, "I know about you. Please do me that favor." And I talked with Jeannie, and she says, "Hey, go ahead." And so I made it. And so I went out to that club that night, and walked in and we sat down. And I had met Maynard before, in Hollywood see. And so when we got ready to hit, I said well here it goes, and where it stops nobody knows, but I'm going to give it the best shot, and everybody's falling out laughing.

Jean: He had some great young trumpet players.

Jim: Yeah.

MR: And some hard arrangements too.

Jim: Wooo, yeah. He had this lead trumpet player, who was also a fine educator too. And he was just a wonderful —

Jean: And Speedy was on the drums.

Jim: And Speedy Jones was playing the drums, and Jackie Byard was playing piano.

Jean: It was a good band.

Jim: So the rhythm section was — a really good band you know, a fantastic band. And we had a lot of fun.

Jean: I like big bands. That's sort of my first experience in jazz.

Jim: That's a powerful experience you know. But I think all the youngsters, if they have an opportunity if they play in the marching band or whatever, have an opportunity to play some big band music, you know, it's on another level. Even a good strong marching band is a heck of a level too. There's a heck of a high you know. Or a concert band is a heck of a high. But then you get into a jazz band and it's like whew.

MR: There's another level there.

Jim: Another level. And they all have their levels. That's why I said to try to say which is my favorite, is very difficult for me, because they're all very — for me anyway — very positive. I accept everything that went with it, because that's what made it positive you see.

Jean: And that's the only way you can hang out.

Jim: It's the only way.

Jean: To be a musician you have to be, I think, super flexible. Because otherwise, how could you make it at all?

Jim: And also that coincides with, even though they coined that phrase "jazz" and they refer to "improvisation," — the act of improving on something, right, improvisation, that's what it is. That's what I explain to my kids you see. I say everybody does that on this planet. Nobody knows everything. So living life is a total improvisational experience. And those who are trying to fix it so it's like one-two-three, eventually find out it doesn't work one-two-three all the time. They've got to deal with the law of permutation.

MR: Do you find that some of your students have more success simply because of their personalities? That they're more easy going or willing to take chances?

Jean: I think so.

Jim: Yeah, yeah. Well because that's that freedom we speak about in terms of personal expression again you see.

Jean: You have to be fearless.

Jim: Yes, yes.

Jean: And that comes from having confidence.

Jim: Really.

Jean: And I think — I don't think you could teach anybody that. I think a lot of their early life experiences with their folks and maybe even before they're born, I think there's a heck of a lot to even deal with that. Because most real fearful people, they can accomplish a lot in another direction, but I don't think they can be a musician. Not a jazz musician, and be that fearful. It has something also to do with faith.

Jim: That's it.

Jean: Like someplace, somewhere, somebody needs a good band? Because you just have to feel like tomorrow's going to be okay. And then there comes the other side, like you go up that mountain, and you go along, and you're on the road and you're thinking next gig, whatever. Then you get to a point in everybody's life where you start feeling, I don't know if I can do that. And a lot of it has to do with the physical body. If they've taken care of it or all of a sudden they get a little twinge here or there, and they start losing that faith. And that's when you see them putting the horns behind the bed or in the closet, and try to find something else to do. Now I'll tell you, in my experience I've found that — to

be a crucible for every musician. I don't care whether he's classical or Gospel or a jazz musician. There comes a time when you have to decide whether you're going to really continue. And to a musician, they have to play — like to play. See jazz musicians have to play, they always say that. Every musician comes to that point in his life where he has to decide whether he's going to continue. And Jimmy and I have been around here long enough to know when they're really struggling with that. Because it doesn't happen overnight. It happens over a period, I've found, of about seven years. On again, off again, on again. Toward the end of that seven years, it seems to be more off than on, but they seem to resign themselves. It takes about seven years for them to resign themself to the fact that they're no longer going to either keep up with what's going on, or want to stay on the road, or want to put up with the diminishing physical. And that is so — it's a sad thing. We've seen it all up and down the road playing different places.

Jim: And really in a sense it's something — well it's not equal to — but in a sense it's like dealing with a thoroughbred horse.

Jean: Yes. A thoroughbred horse.

Jim: A horse. He's geared.

Jean: He's geared to run in that race you know.

Jim: And that's what it lives for you see.

Jean: And then pretty soon it can't. And I don't know, I guess it's just like boxers or anything else. There comes a time, but I think we need more — what can I say — I say we need more places for people like us to talk, to go and talk this thing, before it happens. So that at least the preparation won't be so terrible. I don't know what you would call it, but I think we need a place, where musicians can go and talk about that.

MR: We need some support in dealing.

Jean: Some kind of support system, in the musical — among musicians — so that they can say well I can call, not a Reverend Gensel, because he just passed, but I mean a group of people that have been there, that have decided how they managed that, how they came away from it with grace, and how to maintain your personage. And that's the one thing I find the saddest thing, that I've seen, as long as I've been playing. Forty years I've been playing. And that's the saddest thing. When you see them quit. "Oh I'm not playing anymore" and that. But they need support. And I think we should really have a place, or some organization or something where a guy can go, or a woman, when they decide to stop their life's work.

MR: Do you think it sometimes comes from knowing how to deal with perhaps the diminishing physical skill at what they do? Like let's say a trumpet player has made his mark as a high note man, right? And it gets to the point where they can't quite get up to

where they used to. And unless they can figure out, well I can't quite do that but I can do—

Jim: That's where the decision comes in.

Jean: That's where the decision comes see. And most guys don't make it.

Jim: Yeah. Because in a sense, in terms of dealing with the attitude of achieving, it's like they don't seem to have arrived at the attitude of dealing with the art of feeling expedience. Do you know what I mean when I say that? I learned that from the service. In other words, you're out in the wilderness. You don't know anything about the wilderness. But at the same time, you go through all your agony etcetera, and pretty soon, bang, that creative energy coming from all that environment plus yourself, tells you what to do because you stopped to listen. And you listen and you act on it. So it's the same thing, in a sense, when you're playing. If you don't listen to what you're playing, if you don't hear what you're playing, then you're a trained robot, technically, mechanically, like mass production, bing-bing-bing-bing. But there is no spirit involved in terms of equating to soul expression, feeling. It's all intellectual.

Jean: They have to find a part for themselves once they break down like that.

Jim: Because being around a lot of lead players, and at the same time as a soloist — like you take Maynard Ferguson. Now, lead player, solo and everything, "chops a mile."

Jean: He was born with that.

Jim: He was born with that. I saw him when I was thirteen years old. His mother and father would escort him at the Crystal Beach you know, with his band you see? You follow me? He had it. But everybody else who finally heard him, assumed whatever they wanted to assume, of how he got that way. He was born to do what he do. Like when I got in the band, he had five trumpets.

Jean: And they were trying to beat Maynard. And they're trying to beat every note.

Jim: Up high, that's the point, see? Not out-jazz him. They're trying to — see that's where all the high stuff comes in you see. They're trying to out-high him, and the lead player is trying to warn him, because they're youngsters you know.

Jean: They're cool though.

Jim: Oh, they're arrogant and everything, they didn't want to hear it.

Jean: "You don't know what you're talking about old man."

Jim: See Maynard is still moving around, playing, no matter how somebody want to criticize, why he doesn't have the chops he used to, well heck, the person talking don't have what they had. That's why the tune was written "Things Ain't What They Used to Be." That's the main reason why it was written, believe me. So that's where that whole thing kind of comes in, in terms of dealing with that attitude about the whole thing. Because if that was the goal, the top goal, just to be a high note player, well then eventually you'll run out,

you don't even have too much of dealing with the law of permutation. In other words, to make do with what you've got. That's why I'll get back to the theory of expedience. In other words you'll find out — and naturally, you make do with what you've got. All of a sudden you get sensitized and you know which is poison and which isn't. Because you've got to eat. Well how did you survive? Well I ate bugs, I ate this bug and I ate that bug, and then I ate this one and it made me sick so I know not to mess with that again because, you know, and if I recognize that it means I'm still living so that's what I'm after. So you follow me?

Jean: Well they did, they had this big apartment building in New York City for musicians that retired and stuff. And Dizzy Gillespie I think had this hospital set up where he could go and get treatments or something, down in New Jersey somewhere. But that's sort of like what I'm speaking of. Because that we speak a different language. And so when we get put out to pasture, we should be around people that have done what we have done.

Jim: Somebody to talk to.

Jean: Like she said, one of the saddest things, like was when Papa Jo Jones was like a mentor you see and everything. I mean he raised me professionally and everything. And wherever we went after we left New York, and I was called to Bennington to teach and then Wisconsin and finally L.A. But the thing is is that he would show up at my first concert, wherever I held it. And nobody'd tell him.

Jean: He'd just be sitting there backstage there in the chair with his handkerchief.

Jim: Yeah. I'd come in and he'd be there. Fantastic. What an inspiration you know, to have that kind of back-up.

Jean: Really it makes you feel very special.

Jim: And then, as we moved, wherever we would come, he knew and we'd tell him, look Jo, whenever you feel out of sorts, where we are, you've got a home.

Jean: And he came and stayed with us many a time.

Jim: And sometime he'd stay one week or two weeks, or sometimes a day, bing and he's gone, or he's going to see some other musicians like up in San Diego then go to L.A., that type of thing, make his rounds.

Jean: He told everybody I put him out because I wouldn't let him smoke. Well, he was a chain smoker. And I told him I said, "Jo Jones, you're going to have to go out on the patio and smoke." And so he went back to New York and we got calls all week long, "You threw Jo Jones out?" "You put Papa Jo out?" I said yes we did.

Jim: And then when we got to New York and everything, everybody was still talking about it.

Jean: He told everybody I put him out. But he was smoking too much. Because I had a bronchial thing, and I'm trying to sing too, and so I was really getting that second hand smoke then you know.

MR: Well he certainly was one of the important people in the line of drummers, wasn't he?

Jim: Yeah.

Jean: And George Duvivier was another.

Jim: George Duvivier was another you see.

Jean: And in fact who was that, John Young? John Young is one of our friends here. He's a musician who used to play at the Apollo Theater.

Jim: Former saxophone player.

Jean: But he's a very good friend of Milt Hinton's. And he called us up last week and he said Milt Hinton called him up and told him, "John, I went to a funeral of one of our friends last week." And John said, "yeah?" He said yeah he was talking to the funeral director and everybody was getting ready to leave, and he said he told the funeral director, gee whiz, I've been out here too much this year. He said three or four of my friends have been laid to rest. And so the funeral director asked him, "Well how old were they?" "Well one was 70, one was 72, and one was 75." So the funeral director says, "Well how old are you?" He says "I'm 89." He said, "Well you might as well not go home, you might as well stay here."

Jim: That cold, wasn't it?

MR: You don't say that to Milt Hinton.

Jean: He said the man told him that.

Jim: He called up John Young, and John Young called us. I said oh please. And that's the other thing about sharing.

Jean: Yeah sharing.

Jim: And that the way in terms of how we came up, with that whole — there was always family. You always, "Hey, how you feeling today, everything all right?" And if they weren't together, wherever they were, they could be in Europe, and all of a sudden they'd get this thing about, well let me call Jim and Jeannie. Say hi, how y'all doing, blah, blah, blah, blah. Well I'll be home so-and-so and so-and-so, but I was just thinking about you so I just wanted to let you know. And that's the way it was, that whole connection. And that, to me, represents the oasis. And that's what we need, is an oasis, not only for the musicians, but for the whole human race.

Jean: Jimmy — the whooole human— it's true, we do need it.

Jim: Well I mean that's how we're all going to get in tune to this— one sun and one moon out here.

Jean: Because my mother, she's a bit more pessimistic, she calls us, she listens to everything. She calls us up and she says, "Listen have you heard that song 'The Whole World is a Ghetto' by that group called War?"

Jim: That was pretty wild.

Jean: I said what? She says, "You know they're right."

MR: Is this recent? Fairly recent?

Jim: That's when they had that record. They had that hit on there.

Jean: Yeah. She listens to everything. She's 89 now.

Jim: Yeah. She's surprising, all the time.

MR: Well you guys sound like maybe you are or could become the Milt and Mona Hinton of the San Diego area.

Jean: Oh, I don't know.

MR: I mean there's certain people that you like to be around. Because they give what you guys are talking about.

Jean: That's why the Sweet Baby Blues Band was so special.

Jim: Really.

Jean: It was Curtis Peagler, Red Callender, Jimmy Noone, see and John Harris. Now John Harris is the only one left from our old group. You know he played with Carmen McRae, he played with Horace Silver, and quite a few. And he's one of the most sensitive drummers. Jo Jones was crazy about him.

Jim: And so was Ed.

Jean: Ed Thigpen.

Jim: Ed Thigpen. And Roy Haynes even liked him.

Jim: Roy Haynes loved him, you know, because both of them came up to the Vine Street Grill when we were playing, and they were just sitting there checking out John. He said be sure, I want to meet him, have him come to my table. Because he says I don't believe what I'm seeing and hearing simultaneously. He said I haven't seen this in years. A drummer, the way he is comping and playing and expressing.

Jean: And he can catch a trumpet player in mid-air. He can tell whether he's going to split a note or not. He hits his bass drum, and then the note just comes out of the trumpet. That's the way Papa Jo was.

Jean: Yeah, Papa Jo was. And I don't know —

Jim: Use certain cymbals and do the same thing, or whatever.

Jean: And he walks around in their heads.

Jim: And he knows. And that's where he's such a valuable accompanist. And I could see why Carmen McRae would love him, see because we worked with her too. But he's the last one of the old band. In our new band now we have Ricky Woodard, we have Nolan Shaheed, we have Richard Reid on bass. We call him "Roughouse." And we express to the audience, if you don't behave we're going to let Richard Reid fall on you.

MR: I take it he's a fairly big man.

Jean: He's a big guy.

Jim: He comes in the door sideways.

MR: He comes in the door sideways?

Jim: Well he got his face through—

Jean: He's a big old guy.

Jim: But then there's the one gigantic—

Jean: And we have Ernie Fields. Now Ernie Fields played baritone and also —

Jim: Bass clarinet. And clarinet.

Jean: And clarinet. But he and his dad were both put into the Hall of Fame in Oklahoma — the first time they ever had a father and son combination in Oklahoma.

MR: Speaking of fathers and sons, was the Jimmy Noone that played with you, was he the son of the Chicago Jimmy?

Jean: Yes.

Jim: Jimmy Noone out of New Orleans.

Jean: New Orleans? Chicago.

Jim: Yeah.

MR: Because when I first saw that on the record, I said, wait a minute — I had to go to my encyclopedia because that's so cool.

Jean: I think one of the videos, was the last thing that he played on, Jimmy Noone.

Jim: That's the one where he did the club date, right?

Jean: That's right. That's the one that they put into the Library of Congress.

Jim: Yeah, we got inducted into the Library of Congress. That, and also the "Three Generations of Blues." Both of those are in.

MR: Well let me talk about your music for a bit. You have certain piano licks I think you like a lot.

Jean: Yes.

MR: [scats] I mean I hear that, right?

Jean: Yes.

MR: As soon as I hear that, I mean it sets up so much. It sets up the tempo—

Jean: It does.

MR: It sets up a nice groove.

Jean: That's true.

MR: And it's a sound that I will associate with you. And when you come up with — I mean you seem to have quite a bag of licks. Are these things, when you sit to write an arrangement, are they things that you hear in your head beforehand? Or do you need to hear the tune first? How do you decide exactly what to write behind a certain song? Is that something you can answer?

Jim: Well actually, fundamentally, I'm a firm believer in going into the aspect of the intuitive side for utmost, as far as the intellectual part, I mean given the scientific lean and the voice of notes and things like that. Because even intuitively, I get sounds that I hear, and when I hear it then I go—

Jean: And it depends on who's solo. See if we know it's Snooky, then he knows certain things that help support what Snooky does. Right?

Jim: Yeah and then writing, like when we do the group sounds and things like that, and Jeannie's background, when we're playing for Jeannie, there's a certain nuance that happens, in terms of everybody. So that we just get that wonderful, how can I say it, homogeneous —

Jean: That's a good word.

Jim: Feeling. And out of it comes the sound.

Jean: And sometimes we tease them you know. Sometimes we make a riff, it's one of the soloist's favorite things that they play, and we'll put it in the riff. Then they'll say—

Jim: No that was the intent.

Jean: We'll put it in the riff then they'll start to do it, and it's there, so then—

Jim: Now they've got to go somewhere else.

MR: Hey, you know, Ellington used to do that all the time too, right? I like that thing, I think I'll write a tune around it.

Jim: He was a main thief boy. You could hear him, when the guys would take a solo, and he'd be playing, then answer, and go hmmm. And you could tell, he really liked it because all in and out he'd be playing it all along.

Jean: To be sure to don't forget it.

MR: He could have gone broke if he had to pay royalties to all the fellows that he took licks from.

Jean: Snooky had certain things, Curtis Peagler had his certain thing, and naturally Cat Daddy and Ricky Woodard, he had his certain thing. You'd always know it's Ricky because you hear this thing.

Jim: Yeah. Once you hear it, oh, that's Ricky.

Jean: That's their schtick. Everybody has their stamp of what — like Sweets you know. [scats] And Curtis always did that. [scats] And so on the last record, "The Good News Blues," we did Mr. CP and we dedicated it to him. So we took all of his pet phrases and put it together on that song. It's on the record we gave you.

MR: Cool.

Jim: And on the soloing part.

Jean: We took his whole solo [scats].

Jim: And we saved it.

Jean: That was just like Curtis.

Jim: And it was really funny watching him run into it.

MR: I played that?

Jean: Because since he died, you know, really, everybody misses him. Because he could really set a fire.

Jim: And in all sincerity, the two of us, and also a couple of the other guys, they feel, every time Curtis makes his presence on that bandstand.

Jean: Yeah. Because I'll never forget—

Jim: They'll mention it.

Jean: We went to New Orleans, right after Jimmy Noone died. Because we were supposed to do this New Orleans Jazz Festival. And Jimmy Noone died in April, no, March, and we were supposed to be there in April. And so we had Ricky bring his clarinet to play the part that Jimmy Noone would have played. And Ricky started playing "Ain't Nobody's Business" he's got this thing, and all of a sudden he took his clarinet out, his mouthpiece and he looked at it and then he started playing, and it sounded just like Jimmy Noone. Everybody knew it.

Jim: Jimmy Noone was playing through him.

Jean: Everybody knew it.

Jim: And people were walking, in the tent, and it was crowded already, but everybody stopped, and you could hear all the silence. And they looked right at him.

Jean: Yeah.

Jim: What a moving thing.

Jean: It was very, very weird. It was really, it really was truly Jimmy Noone.

Jim: Yeah. Because he was ever-present.

Jean: My goodness, gracious, I'll never forget that.

Jim: It was really something.

MR: How is that for the power of music?

Jim: Yes. Whoever comes up with that power. They can call it what they want, but we know that it exists. It doesn't make any difference what you want to call it.

MR: Well you're quite a poet I have to say. I had to write down one of my favorite lines of yours: "You brought me a brand new hatchet/to cut down my weeping willow tree."

Jim: Ain't that wild?

MR: Yeah. "No more bending over backwards."

Jean: "No bitter tears from me."

MR: That is poetry.

Jean: Thank you. That's Helen Dance's favorite song by the way.

Jim: Yeah it is. Yeah. She says, "Don't tell Stanley. That's my favorite — don't tell Stanley."

MR: I may have to say that.

Jean: It's a real woman song. Like a declaration.

MR: What is it that — this is probably an unanswerable question, but — the blues has been so much a part, it is a music in itself, but also giving rise to rock & roll, and being so much a part of jazz music. I've always been fascinated by the blues as a form of music that allows so much to be done with it, over and over and over. That the form is so inevitable, you can always feel where you are, and maybe that's one of the beauties of it.

Jean: Maybe that is.

Jim: Yeah. And the simplicity of it.

Jean: Here we go again, simplicity.

Jim: Simplicity, and the way it falls you see, no matter how the melody goes, but in terms of dealing with the progression, you know, fundamentally, it's symmetrical. Perfectly symmetrical. There's no chord that jerks you around and on a wrong beat.

Jean: No. No Stravinsky there.

Jim: Yeah. It just leads you right into the next thing.

Jean: And it's so comforting.

Jim: Because they are statements. It's like telling a story, you know, telling a story you see. And so it's all there. It's like talking all the time. A conversation. And like speaking on behalf of the grooves, in terms of expression, there is not one act of emotion or intellect, you just name it, that deals with life on this planet earth, that can't be expressed with the blues.

Jean: With the blues. It's like they say Shakespeare only had twelve stories, but that he was sort of like an astrologer, the twelve different signs you know, and each one has its own characteristics. So you could really—

Jim: Back to the twelve again.

MR: I think we're on to something here.

Jim: You'd better believe it.

Jean: Well actually he said it's all universal. But that's what makes it so wonderful about the blues, it's universal and you could take it anywhere. You can take it to China, you can take it to BongBong, Africa. People will stop.

Jim: And they recognize it.

Jean: And they recognize it.

Jim: Because they call it spirit music.

Jean: We were playing at the Sheraton, upstairs at the bar, and this African came in, he had on a suit, a three-piece suit. He stood there for a minute, and he went back upstairs and he came back in his robe. The whole regalia. He says, "I must address you." He says, "You are playing spirit music." And he sat down.

Jim: That's exactly what he said.

Jean: So help me. And I said to myself, ohh. So we kept playing. But that's how much he gave to it. He went up and had to re-dress.

Jim: And to have that experience was an affirmation, a confirmation of what is. Whether we understand it totally or not, but it's a confirmation, whatever we realize that it is — but it helps to expand us and keep going. That's what's talking about the faith you know, to help sustain and maintain they call it.

Jean: That was a real experience.

Jim: To get to the next one. That's right. It's really something. And now that we naturally, via high tech communications and everything, and naturally you hear on mass consciousness about global observations etcetera you know, and the whole bit. But it's going to be interesting. We're going to hear some blues to come out of China, Japan, all over the world, Turkey, it doesn't make any difference, India, it doesn't make any difference.

Jean: I think so too.

Jim: And you're going to hear a reminiscent aspect of the blues.

Jean: A Muddy Water fan.

MR: It has to go on the great list of twentieth century inventions, doesn't it?

Jean: Oh I think so.

Jim: The blues? Oh yeah.

Jean: Let's say nineteenth and twentieth.

Jim: But, yeah that's true, but in reality, it's always been here. Really.

Jean: Somebody told me, long years ago, that there was African chiefs that went down this great river in Africa and they sang a song that was the melody of "Swing Low Sweet Chariot." And I read that in one of the history books that we have, out of our books at home. And I said to myself, why not?

Jim: Because remember it was part of that ritual.

Jean: They put them on the boat.

Jim: In the boat you know, and there'd be a falls — you know you put them in a river, then there's a falls.

Jean: There's a falls that they go down.

Jim: And as the boat would do this, then there would be an infection of the spirit of the person in the boat.

Jean: So they sang "Swing Low Sweet Chariot." The melody. See the slave words, whatever they — is this, to me, is this a remembrance of that, brought here, and then they just put their words to it? But I'll tell you it's hard to say.

Jim: I refer to certain aspects, of like I think we all have what we consider an aspect of — not to minimize it — race memory.

Jean: I think it's in the genes.

MR: You think it's in the genes?

Jean: I think there's a memory that comes with all of it.

Jim: It's like a recurring — because we have every — as it's spoken of from a scientific point of view, even though we say we forgot, it's still there. And then at the same time we say we forgot, then at whatever time it happens, we recall it. So that's like telling us something. That what we think we've lost we haven't lost. Truthfully it's still there.

Jean: Otherwise what would you say to a person that's three years old and writes all kinds of sonatas?

Jim: You know, like Mozart.

MR: Right. What was he doing at five years old?

Jean: You've got to really think that that's — and we saw a kid in New Jersey. He was about nine years old. And we were playing on the pier. And he was playing this — his mother and father brought him up to our group, "Our son can play the alto sax. Can he sit in with you?" And we say, "Yeah." We always welcome. So he took his sax horn out of his case and put the mouthpiece on and I said, "What would you like to play?" He said, "Now Is The Time." We said, "Okay, you set it." He set it [scats] — and played Charlie Parker — and sound and all, everything that was Charlie Parker this kid played. I couldn't believe it. We couldn't believe it. And he was born to do that. He was born to do that. In fact, the guys took him aside and were talking mouthpieces with him and everything. I really wonder what happened to the kid.

Jim: And to watch his attitude was something. Because —

Jean: He was grown.

Jim: He was somebody, you know what I mean? Without a doubt. You watch him and you know he knows he's somebody. I mean very big.

Jean: Yes. And he wasn't a kid right off. He wasn't playing like a kid.

Jim: Like a young soul with — like a young body with an old soul, that's what I'm trying to say, you know what I mean?

Jean: We didn't tolerate him. He tolerated us.

Jim: Because he took over.

Jean: He did. Into the band.

Jim: And righteously so. He rounded off everything, and hanging out.

MR: Unbelievable.

Jean: No, it's true.

Jim: Well when she mentioned that, this other kid popped to my mind. We just saw him on T.V. It was the kid that was doing the country thing with the little—

Jean: Oh, with the little accordion.

MR: Concertina or something?

Jean: Yeah, and he was singing a Cajun song.

Jim A Cajun song. And he was just singing — and then when he would [scats] when he would do that—

Jean: He was old.

Jim: He was as old as Methuselah.

Jean: And the time was just perfect.

Jim: And he was this high.

Jean: So where does he come from?

Jim: It's amazing. You know he felt and knew what he was singing.

Jean: Yes he did.

Jim: Not just mimicking. Because there is that too. But he was in it.

MR: It wasn't Suzuki.

Jim: No definitely not.

Jean: No, that was too tough for Suzuki.

MR: Well let me catch up on a couple of things in your history here. When did you first have a chance to accompany some of those singers — Dinah Washington and —

Jean: Actually, that was all through the 50s, most of it. Big Maybelle and Jimmy Witherspoon and Dinah Washington and Mr. Five by Five — Jimmy Rushing, who came. And I had never played [sings] "I want a little girl to call my own."

Jim: Wynonie?

Jean: No. Jimmy Rushing. But none of them had music. They never had any music. And I was used to reading everything see? So I said, "Well I don't know that song." He said, "It goes like this," and he sits down to play more piano than most piano players. A very excellent pianist. Show me the bridge [scats] — whooo, okay. But he was very nice. And I played with Big Mama Thornton and they were all—

Jim: And Joe Williams.

Jean: And Joe Williams, and Wynonie Harris. And it was lucky because it was all in that same area like Columbus, Springfield and Dayton. Because we were like the house band in Ohio. Cleveland Ohio. And some of it was in Buffalo, New York where they had this club where I played for Big Maybelle. You've heard of Big Maybelle?

MR: Sure.

Jean: Big Maybelle was — I had a day off and I had gone to bed and the bass player, his name was Shakespeare, we called him Shakespeare because he could read his own palm. And he came knocking on the door "Jeannie! Jeannie! Get up. There's a woman down here made me give her all my money." I knew, he was so tight, he would tell us, "I'm not buying any Christmas gifts so don't buy me anything." That's how tight he was. So I

knew if she made him give her all his money, I knew that something was really up. So I got dressed really fast and we went down and there were limousines all around this club. We could hardly push our way in. And here was this lady with this baby face. She weighed almost 350 pounds, and she was going through the aisle singing [sings] "Baby please don't go." And as she walked she had these pockets, and people were stuffing hundred dollar bills in. And she was still singing. She would hit that hip and make that money go around in there and keep moving, but tears was coming down her cheeks singing this song. And I never heard or saw anything like that. This was an inter-racial audience. It was full of people with limousines who had come from miles around to watch this woman sing. She could really, really work a crowd. And she could make me cry. And she'd sing songs — you know I'll tell what was wonderful about people like her. And Joe Williams, a lot of them, they all sang not just blues, not just rhythm and blues, they'd sing songs like [sings] "If God made me a king/I'd be but a fool for you." They'd sing all those beautiful ballads.

Jim: Or they'd sing "Trees."

Jean: And "Trees." [sings] "I think that I shall never see/A poem lovely as a tree." Yeah that was a blind man. That was his thing. Because I played for Al. Yeah, Al Hibbler. And he would hang out at this night club after we got through playing the show, and it was called Benny Rivers. And he'd tell all the guys, and they'd have bets, and money was passing along, and he says, "All right Al, what's coming now?" He said he could tell an ugly woman or a pretty one. He's blind you know, right? And so now they didn't know how he was figuring that out. And so he'd listen, and say, "That's an ugly one." They'd say okay, and give him the money. "Here come a pretty one." "Oh, this one is gorgeous." And he'd say, "You sure you can't see?" He said no, he could tell the way they walk. He said ugly people dragged their feet. And he would win all their money. They never did figure out how he did it.

Jim: Well the attitude and the sound.

Jean: The attitude and the sound, see the sound.

Jim: From the sound and the way—

Jean: See ugly women he said ugly women dragged their feet.

Jim: That's right. And they walked on the heels on the back of their shoes.

Jean: And that really made me be aware — I said this guy made more money than he made on the gig. He was a funny guy. He says, "I can tell a Cadillac." He'd put his hand on it, and he could feel the paint. He could tell the different paint. He could tell the difference between a Cadillac and a Ford. I saw this with my own eyes.

MR: So you were in a house band and the singers would come through. And you'd just do your best to fit into their styles.

Jean: That was very easy for us because first of all we were very good musicians. Second of all, they would come in the night before they were supposed to open, and watch the other guy close. So we had a chance to talk to them you know, sit at the bar and hang out and talk. And so we'd connect with their attitude right away see. And in fact I was thinking about Jo Jones' cousin was Wynonie Harris. That's his first cousin. And Wynonie, when he rehearsed, he'd say, "Okay, play me a shuffle in B flat." [brief scat]. "That's enough. The rehearsal is over." He called me "Miss Box." Because he called the piano a box. He said "That's Miss Box. Miss Box is here." And then, sometimes at intermission he'd put this turban on. And he and our bass player would tell fortunes, and make extra money. Look, he was a very psychic person. He really could read. Wynonie Harris.

Jim: Yeah. He's clairvoyant.

Jean: Very, very clairvoyant. And so was Shakespeare. So they used to sit and make extra money at intermission.

Jim: What was it about Joe Williams in Buffalo? He came through all this snow, that big one.

Jean: We don't know how he got there, it was one of those big Buffalo snows.

Jim: Unusual — Syracuse, Buffalo, Watertown.

Jean: And Miles Davis was supposed to be there, and Joe Williams. He was there. They made it through because — Sarah Vaughan couldn't make it. But Joe made it, but his band didn't make it. So they called us to get an eight piece group together to play with Joe Williams. And he was very nice, but every time he'd see a lady piano player they'd go — like they're in pain. And it really made me mad but I knew I could do whatever he wanted. He says, "Okay." He put the music up there. And I started playing Blues in G, I'll never forget it.

Jim: Yeah, he asked you.

Jean: He says, "Go ahead and play." He says, "You open it up." I think he wanted to find out where I was at before he started. And so I started playing this big old baby grand, a Steinway, and the audience started going oooh. Then they started cheering. And he said, "Take another one, take another one." He was smart, see? But I'll never forget that. Then we played his show, bang-bang-bang-bang, right down like that.

Jim: Yeah. He rode that energy.

Jean: Yeah, he had a good time. He said, "This is the best band ever — I want to take you guys on the road."

Jim: Yeah, we wailed behind him.

Jean: That was a great experience. That was the first time I'd ever played for him.

MR: Well he knows how to work the audience. And he knows how to take advantage of the musicians.

Jean: He really does, he does.

Jim: Have you got a kleenex?

Jean: Yeah, he was a dear. And such a sweet person. You know some people have attitudes when they get on the bandstand. But he was wonderful.

MR: Well can you tell me about the first time that you heard one of your own arrangements played that really gave you a thrill?

Jim: Yeah.

Jean: It was Clyde Reisinger for me. When they did—

Jim: Yeah. That was really one of the thrills because we weren't in Buffalo then.

Jean: No. We were in New York City.

MR: With who now?

Jim: Clyde Reisinger.

Jean: His big band.

Jim: He used to be a great lead player, and he lived in Hollywood, in Los Angeles too, and so he worked the studio and did a lot of lead playing and stuff like that. And then he went to New York and that's when we saw him again.

Jean: We rehearsed with the big band.

Jim: We rehearsed with the big band and we recorded with him. Those dates were set up, where we featured him. That was on "Homeward Bound."

Jean: "Homeward Bound." One of the tunes we wrote.

Jim: And he just loved that, and he had never had anybody write a feature for him, and set him up. He said at the time he considered it the best ballads that he's ever enjoyed performing.

Jean: A great arranger. Who had the arrangements done? I want to talk about him. Because he was supposed to send it back so we could get copies of it.

Jim: Wasn't that the drummer that has the band?

Jean: You probably interviewed him anyway.

Jim: Right now I can't think of it. I'm looking at his face.

Jean: And then when we heard ourselves on radio for the first time with the Sweet Baby Blues Band.

Jim: Yeah, that was the other thrill. On record.

Jean: It was really startling, to say the least. That really was a thrill.

Jim: It was mind blowing. Just in a sense because, I'm trying to recall when I wrote this or wrote that. And it was kind of hard to record.

Jean: It sounded like somebody else.

Jim: Yeah. Because like I said, you know, because I did a lot, in fact both of us did a lot with our intuitivity, you know, our intuitiveness you see. And so you give those things, and it's not only in the writing but also solo-wise. So to recall what you played, is very

difficult for either one of us. And then when we hear it back, it sounded like somebody else was playing. And then you realize that it's not anybody else, because —

MR: Was I really on this?

Jim: Yeah. Where was I when this was happening?

MR: Well you've both been in the education field for a while. Is there any way you can teach intuitiveness?

Jean: I don't think so.

Jim: No. Intuitiveness I think is endowed. And I think everybody is endowed.

Jean: Everybody has some of it.

Jim: I would say everybody has a certain aspect of intuitiveness, depending upon how it's utilized or exercised. Because to me, that's part of the sensitivity that exists in all of us in terms of dealing with survival.

Jean: I'm always amazed how a person can be intuitive in this area, and completely blank right here. That always amazes me. Because to me if you're intuitive, you're intuitive. But again there's a different era now, before everything became so compartmentalized. Weird.

Jim: Compartmentalized. In other words, coming into the 50s, right out of the late 40s, but especially after World War II, on up to now in terms of high tech, we entered into the age of specialists. So we divided up the human body. You've got an ache on your left side, you go to see a doctor who does the left ear. The right side, the doctor does the right ear. And the eyes, the same way. So you're all divided up. And you've got to go through all this to find out what's wrong.

MR: That's right. And you've got to see about six of them first before they decide which.

Jim: And in the meantime they've written up all these prescriptions for you, and it breaks down the rest of your body while you're trying to take care of it. Not all of them.

Jean: It's rough.

Jim: So it becomes pretty wild. You know that's why I think the basic sense again of why we go back to that education, having that foundation you see, and when you deal with the nature of what is, and then go from there. And lots of luck.

MR: You guys started playing professionally about what time?

Jean: From nine to one.

MR: That's standard hours, I know. More than that and we get overtime, right? I mean was it in the mid to late 50s that you started playing?

Jean: I think I can say that I was a professional in 1950. That is in jazz music and classical music.

MR: I was just wondering if the rock & roll era, and the British invasion of rock & roll and Elvis and all of that, if it affected your employment.

Jean: It did, it did. That's why we were slick enough to go to Canada. Because Canada was twenty years behind the United States. Exactly twenty years. So when we went to Canada, we were like heroes and they really thought that we were the cat's meow. And we could play Duke Ellington and we could play Count Basie, and could play, of course we did, we had to do "Blueberry Hill" — Fats Domino, they'd say in Quebec. But by the same time Louis Armstrong had a hit on "Blueberry Hill" also. And although we threw in some of those kind of songs, we'd always do jazz. We'd always do "Cherokee" like for the band tune, and take fours. And they'd all be amazed. In fact, that's where I saw Dizzy, about the same thing, because his band was staying in the same hotel we were during that time when nobody could get arrested in the United States. You'd go to Toronto or go to Quebec City. That was like going to Europe. So we were smart enough to kind of move ourselves around. You only had to come out, like about every three or six months you had to come out for two weeks, or become a citizen or something like that. And that's why a lot of times we'd come to Buffalo and hang out with the jam sessions and whatever.

Jim: They closed it at midnight.

Jean: Yeah, on Sunday. So that extended our time. Because everybody else was getting killed. We had one short period in, I'll say about 1954, when we were in Canada and we almost got clobbered in Canada. The Queen came over and she had decided she loved country & western. And for a short time, that's all there was in Toronto, and every joint but ours was country & western people, even though they were from New York. But the Canadians didn't know that. You know these guys come in there from New York because if you've got a red guitar and sing "Red River Valley" you could get a gig in Toronto. And this is true — the whole country went country. It's true. And we had to wait that out. Rock & roll in the United States and country & western, for a while there we didn't work too good.

MR: And you've been with a couple of different record labels.

Jean: Not really. Concord is our main one.

Jim: In terms of our own individual, Concord was the initiator.

MR: When you record, this is almost a silly question in some cases, but do you all play at the same time?

Jean: Well the main thing, they never see the arrangements until they get to the studio. We never rehearse. And most of the stuff we did was one take. Very seldom we had to do two takes, which kept the stuff edgy and fresh.

MR: But I mean you don't record the rhythm section and then do the vocals?

Jean: Oh, no.

MR: I mean, I knew the answer to that because I could tell.

Jean: Well a lot of people didn't. Because Dick, up in Denver that used to do the jazz parties?

MR: Dick Gibson.

Jean: Dick Gibson, when we came up there to do his jazz party, he insisted, on, "I have a good piano player for you." I said, "I'm the piano player." He said, "You didn't do it on your records." He had been playing our records for about four years on his radio show.

Jim: Yeah, you're right.

Jean: And I said, "I've always played my—" He said, "You never did that." I said, "Look at the record." I always play my own music and I never do it and then sing, I always do it at the same time.

Jim: Simultaneously.

Jean: And so he said, "I've got a wonderful piano player for you." I said, "Well I'm going to be it. I'm it."

Jim: It shook him up.

Jean: He didn't want me to play.

Jim: Because he had his own —

Jean: He had his own idea about who.

Jim: It was his plantation.

Jean: Well it was. Shifting everybody around, you play this—

Jim: He has control, because you play over here and put this one—

Jean: And this one with that one and that one, whether they fit or not.

MR: Yeah, that can be a dicey way to play.

Jean: Well, it's a challenge. Those guys came through like champs, because they're all good you know, and they knew it was just a gig.

Jim: But at the same time, the most beautiful thing about it, the caliber of jazz musicians involved you see, they know, they'd met grace, and they know grace. They've been all over the world and they played kings and queens and etcetera. Shahs, and just name it. So there's no way in the world he could shake them up. No way. They'd just give him that grace period.

MR: I've enjoyed hearing from people like Clark Terry and basically what you're saying, that a lot of the musicians I've spoken to along the way have met with either racial or other obstacles along the way, and that they've said to themselves, no way is this going to change me. It's your problem, and I'm comfortable with myself.

Jean: Not only race but sexist. So I get a double whammy. We played for a guy, remember the guy right here in San Diego. And so we came to the place, and this organist was sitting there playing to the bartender. So we told him we wanted to start a jam session. He says, he's from St. Louis, he says, "Oh, okay." He says, "Peanuts Hucko is my friend." He

says, “I know all about jam sessions.” We got this jam session going, and you couldn’t move in there.

Jim: It was on Harbor Island.

Jean: And so, after three weeks, and I said, “Jimmy, it’s time to hit for a raise now,” you know. So we went to the guy, and said it’s time for us to get a raise. He said, “I’m not going to give you a raise,” he told me. I said, “Okay then we’ll go somewhere else. He said, “No, don’t do that.” He said, “But if I give you a raise, I have to give the organ player a raise, because he’s a man.” I said, “But he’s not playing anything. When we came here he was just playing to the bartender. What do you mean?” I said, “But you can do anything you want with your money, as long as you give us a raise.” He refused to give me a raise without giving that guy a raise. He said because he’s a man.

Jim: A real chauvinistic vein.

Jean: And my mom always told me, she said, “When they talk like that,” she said, “just imagine them in boxer shorts and keep moving.”

Jim: Then come up with a great sense of humor.

MR: Keep moving. That’s the important part. So you divide your time now here in San Diego between teaching and going out and playing gigs, and recordings.

Jim: We’ve done clinics and things like that too. Very rewarding I’d say, again, it becomes very difficult because, you know, outside traveling hassles and things like that. But in terms of actual, once you get on the stage for performance, it’s been very — we come out, as they say, smelling like a rose. Hey, whatever we went through before, we don’t even get into it because it was worthwhile to get to this.

MR: Did you ever have the seven year period where you are saying to yourself, I don’t know if I can keep doing this?

Jean: Not yet. I think I’m not too sure, I think we’re very fortunate, and I’m not quite sure why. But so far, so good. And I think because both of us are relatively healthy and even with the advent of the new musicians, they’ve been with us now three years at least, but they’ve fell into the family mode that we love, that we had with Curtis and Red Callender. In fact Cat Daddy told, me, that’s Cat Daddy, we call him Cat Daddy—

Jim: The trumpet player, Nolan.

Jean: He said, “Whenever I get on this band” he says. “I used to say why are those people asking me how I feel?” He couldn’t figure that out. Because although he was the first trumpet player for, lead trumpet player for Count Basie for a while, even at a young age, he had also played with a couple of rock & roll people, and they paid him a great salary and everything, but they just come and do what they’re doing and everybody splits. So he wasn’t quite used to that way, but it’s a family in the group. And gradually these young ones have come into the family, and the way of taking care of each other.

Jim: First they'll call up, hey how are you feeling?

MR: Turn it around and send it back.

Jim: Then we got a gig, and everybody's hugging. "Hey, how you doing, how you feeling?" They hug you and they know how you feel.

Jean: So it's wonderful, I think our second family is just as nice as it was.

Jim: It's like a blessing in a way.

Jean: Because we're very, very, very fortunate.

MR: Tell me about the PBS Special you did with Sippie Wallace.

Jean: And Big Mama? That was our concept. And this lady at KPBS came to us and asked if we wanted to do some kind of special or what we wanted to do. She said it would be a half hour. And so we told her what ideas we had about bringing Big Mama and Sippie Wallace and myself together — three generations of the blues. So she worked very hard, and we got this thing going. And it was the rainiest day. We were doing a jam session, still, and we set it up so that Sippie would do the first, a whole show, an hour. This was at the Belly Up.

Jim: Tavern. Which is up north in Solana Beach.

Jean: And then Big Mama would do hers. And then I would do mine. And at the end of mine we'd do a finale. But we didn't tell Sippie or Big Mama that we were going to do a finale.

Jim: How that was going to go down.

Jean: Because they are very ornery people, both of them, and we didn't want them to throw anything into the works. So Sippie, she did hers, and Big Mama did hers, and then when I did mine, then I said, "Ladies and Gentlemen, now we're going to have a good old fashioned finale. And we're going to call up these ladies, Sippie Wallace and Big Mama Thorton." They stopped. They were at the bottom of the step watching me because they had never heard me sing. And I had played for Big Mama all these years and she had never heard me sing.

Jim: She didn't even know she could sing.

Jean: She didn't know I could sing, see? This was her first time. So they were standing at the bottom of the stage watching me, and so, here they come up on the stage. Now they're going to show this young whippersnapper who— Sippie Wallace came up there and she started singing to Big Mama. And telling her off. Making up lyrics.

Jim: Oh, yeah, she was improvising.

Jean: She was improvising. And so Big Mama would take a part and then Big Mama said, [sings] "Yeah you will come to my house and I'm gonna kick you out of my back door." "Oh no you won't." And I got so intrigued watching them fight, until I forgot I was supposed to sing too.

Jim: And I kind of, because I could see the cameras was on them you know. And I said, "You better get in there because it'll never happen."

Jean: Really. Because I forgot, I was fascinated. I was so used to playing for somebody else. And I said, "Ladies, ladies — you don't have to fuss and fight" you know.

Jim: And when she did it, of course she had that little light growl. I mean she sliced through the whole thing. And when she did that everybody said — immediately, like lightening struck them. And they looked to her, and that's when the camera hit her.

Jean: And so boy it was a great moment. Because they had been fighting in the dressing room.

MR: See now if you had tried to stage that—

Jim: No way.

Jean: No way.

Jim: You know, this is one of the things that paid us off in terms of experience. Now we'd played shows of ours and all that kind of stuff, sepia clubs and all that kind of thing. So you learn that in terms of dealing with the art of improvisation, you've got to have a surprise.

Jean: You can't tell them everything.

Jim: Other than that, everybody knows everything, so everybody's going to play their hot licks or whatever, and it's all over after that. But this way, you get the spontaneity going.

Jean: Yeah. And it's there.

Jim: And I do the same thing with my students. They don't know how the program is going to go until we hit.

Jean: That's true.

Jim: They know the music you know, up to a point. But they don't know what I'm going to do with it once we get on the stage.

Jean: And the guys never knew who our guest artist was going to be.

MR: For that particular—

Jean: For any album we've ever done. They never know who the guest artists were.

Jim: Because oh they'd try to figure that out. They'd call and say well so-and-so, and who's the guest artist? They'd try to get you to slip up.

Jean: But we wouldn't tell them. When Lockjaw flew in from Las Vegas, and they were all, we were getting the stuff together in the studio and he came in. He said, "Gentlemen." And they're ahhhh.

MR: That's a great way to make people come to work too, man.

Jean: And they really played, because they wanted to impress him. They were so happy to see Jaw you know.

Jim: Oh it was a rush, you could feel it you know, a beautiful rush. Really wild.

MR: I think you guys ought to write a book.

Jean: Well we're working on it. You know Sippie and Big Mama were fighting in the dressing room. And one would sit on that end and one sit — and that's the one thing that we didn't know. Now Big Mama is big, she's got a big feet like this. And Sippie's got a little tiny feet. So Sippie says, she says, "You know, my granddaughter bought me these shoes. They're a size four and they're too big." So Big Mama says, "I don't know why you're complaining, you ought to be glad you've got feet." And so then Sippie said a word that I can't say on camera. And so it got really blue in there. And I said to myself, Lordy, nobody knows these two ladies aren't ladies. They're no longer ladies. I never heard such.

MR: Did you ever, when you had first started to conceive of this program, did you think that that might happen?

Jean: No. It never occurred to me. But I forgot that thing, because almost all vocalists, said oh Jeannie, watch it.

MR: She said "almost."

Jean: Sometimes they don't like each other and they call each other names behind each other's back. I don't know why.

Jim: Yeah. They have an ax to grind.

MR: You know I think you have, because you play piano so well, I think it gives you a leg up on your confidence level.

Jean: That's why they do that, because they're at your mercy.

MR: They are sure at your mercy, that's right. And you're not. And I think it makes a big difference.

Jean: Remember that one that had the attitude in Buffalo? Came on and decided, "Well I'm not used to having a woman piano player. And I've had Hank Jones play for me." And I said to myself, why is she saying that? So she put her music up there, and so then she started singing "My Funny Valentine." And so every time she said [sings] "my funny valentine" I moved up a half step. "Sweet funny valentine" another half step. "You made me smile when you're"— I said now that'll teach her. And so after that, she had much respect.

MR: You don't mess.

Jim: You just don't do that. It's just like arguing with the waiter, with your food, you know—

Jean: Then he'll go back in the kitchen and decorate it for you. So don't be messing around.

MR: That should be a book of quotes, you know, the Cheathams say, "Don't mess with the waiter, and don't mess with the piano player."

Jean: So she got respect for me.

MR: I like that. My. Well you really should consider a book you know.

Jean: Well we're kind of working on one.

MR: I mean it's a long process. But you've got a lot of — What was it like working with, you did some Broadway shows and all that.

Jim: Yeah, that was another great experience, a broadening experience you know, to be called in as a sub you see. So every time I did one, there was no rehearsal. And that's where the challenge was. And as you say, state and maintain a competence. Because you had no idea what's going on. Every now and then maybe you had an opportunity to go in maybe to a matinee and sit in the pit, and just see what's going on. But most of the time, like phew. You'd get there an hour ahead of time and then the conductor comes over, oh, you're the substitute, so-and-so. So it would work out.

MR: Plus you have to — it's not like a jazz gig where you're being able to improvise a lot. Reading those notes.

Jim: No. Everything has to be right there. Because you're dealing with the performance on the stage, singing-wise and stuff like that and everything, and dancing and all that bit, so you definitely learn quickly how not to mess with the rhythm by coming in wrong. It's kind of faux pas. It's best you leave it out, because the next phrase, you know the next letter or whatever, rather than try to stick it though, you'll be sticking out there like a sore thumb. Everybody'd be dancing and they'll turn around. What the hell's going on? But that was really, like I say, a very good experience. It taught me a lot, and also in terms of how to share that — that process — share that with, in terms of education, to students. Like dealing with the attitudes and emotions of everybody concerned.

MR: What do you think about the state of jazz today?

Jean: Well it's too hard to answer. It's too hard. I'm not too sure exactly how to answer that.

Jim: Only thing I relate is it's in constant flux.

Jean: And a lot of great kids coming up too.

Jim: A lot of good musicianship, good soul feeling and everything. They're really sincere, and not only in terms of dedicated to the profession, but their dedication shows because they're reaching back in the history and getting the continuity you see. And in other words they've listened, like Papa Jo, pulled my coat, so in turn, I'll pull my coat, so in turn, I'm pulling coats. So we have a relay stick. You pass the relay sticks. So out of that process, you could see some good coat pulling happening. And what has helped, is actually the increase in some aspect of recognizing jazz education, in the schools, and being exposed to it, now even at a much earlier age than ever before in the base, before ten, fifteen, twenty years ago. There's a big increase.

Jean: And the things that you all are doing.

Jim: Well that's a part of it yeah.

Jean: Because jazz has to be listened to, and if they can hear it from people who have done it, instead of imagining what's going down, they can at least see us.

Jim: And the most important thing, if they can see and hear it simultaneously. So if it's live it's even greater, but if not, hey, a videotape or a movie, old movies and things like that, if it's no more than that one little slot. Where like "High Society" we were talking about coming here, and I was watching it the other night, on the late T.V. movie, with Bing Crosby and Louis Armstrong, and Frank Sinatra. And it was a beautiful thing to see. Louis opened up the whole picture you know, and he said now the story began. And then we'd go through the whole thing, and then at the end, here they're doing another number and he plays, and he takes his horn out and he says, "Now the story ends." It was so beautiful.

MR: No one else could have pulled that off.

Jim: Fantastic. Especially when he was so infectious, with his personality.

MR: I noticed that you had played with Ornette Coleman too?

Jim: Actually it was a very short experience, but a very broad one, and that was when he had received a Guggenheim Award and they were doing the "Skies of America."

MR: Oh, yeah, the big orchestral piece.

Jim: With a big orchestra. And so the contractor had contacted a friend of mine, a French horn player, Les Ellman, who was responsible for me playing shows and things like that. And also, my friend Frank Cuomo, who I went to school with at the New York Conservatory of Modern Music, in terms of copying, were also professional copyists and orchestrators and all of that. So in dealing with that beforehand, that's when he had his place on Prince Street. And so what happened, for the rehearsal Les asked me to bring the horn because he wanted to make sure he had everybody covered. And so sure enough we passed the music out and everything. So that's how I got to play with him, because one of the trombone players was late. And so I sat down and he was rehearsing, and he was trying to get the reed section to do something. But he was speaking on behalf of nuances and everything. And he would play it, and he would try to see if he could get them to interpret it as closely as possible to it, and it was a pleasurable job because they were all legit players, really, they weren't all jazz. It was a mixture of jazz players. Like the trombone player played saxes too, a fine jazz musician. And anyway, the trombone player finally showed up and so he was sitting there and he said well what's wrong? He said where's my part? And I realized I had his part, and I said, oh, look here. Here's his part here. And I said there's a bassoon part and I'll take the bassoon part. And so I spent that whole two hours, professional pay of a two hour rehearsal at a small second level, working with my level. And then at the same time, both Les and I had explained to him that under the circumstances he was having such a problem, we thought he'd go broke before he could ever get that recorded. So we suggested to him that, "Look go to England. The scale for every rehearsal and everything is cheaper." And that's where he recorded it. He recorded

it in England. And I've still got the bassoon part. So that was actually my experience with him, which was a great experience to see him handle all this and deal with it. And then finally to get a copy of the recording and see how it came out. And how are you going to beat the BBC?

MR: Tim, why don't you flip that?

Tim: We're at almost two hours.

MR: We are at two hours? Oh my God it's twenty to four. I don't believe it.

Jean: See how you are when you're having fun?

MR: I can't believe it.

Jim: Both of you all are beautiful.

MR: No I saw the sign and I thought you made a mistake. I can't believe it. Well, you guys are going to be celebrating your what anniversary now coming up? That's a real tough question, right?

Jean: Let me see. Well since 1954. So that's 40 and—

Jim: Five. Actually 44.

MR: That's great.

Jim: Yeah, we've been patting our foot to music.

MR: Music keeps you young.

Jean: I think it does.

Jim: You can say that again. I'm a strong voucher for that.

Jean: And you've really got to take care of yourself on the road. See, believe me. And everybody in our new band, they eat grass and seeds. Well Cat Daddy is a professional runner. He's a champion in his age group. And these guys just don't drink. They don't drink, they eat salads and stuff like that.

Jim: That's the truth.

MR: Well this group of guys and you are going to last a long time then I suspect.

Jean: Well as long as we keep drinking our gin and eating our steak.

MR: Balance.

Jean: Got that balance.

MR: Got to have that balance. Well it's been a great pleasure for me to talk to you.

Jim: Oh, mutually so. Believe me. This has been beautiful.

MR: So I look forward to it, and I hope that your next recording is soon.

Jean: We hope so too.

Jim: We hope so too. We're working on it.

MR: And I hope that we can get you out on our end of the country.

Jean: I hope we can bring the whole band out so we can really show what the Kansas City style is.

MR: Well on behalf of Hamilton College, I'd like to thank Jeannie and Jimmy Cheatham for being here today.

Jim: And we sure appreciate it.

MR: And I appreciate your — you know we've had a balance in this conversation too, you know? Kind of the way up here stuff to think about, and kind of that basic blues stuff to think about too.

Jean: Why not?

MR: Well thanks for your time.

Jim: Oh you're welcome. Thank you so much. A real pleasure.